

S05-03 - The Ritual Begins

Player read-aloud

The Keystone finally answers. The Custodian lifts from the ground, glowing like a lantern about to crack.

Scene summary

The Keystone responds, the countdown starts, and the first enemies emerge.

Visible choices

- Protect Custodian
- Intercept skeletons
- Focus fire
- Use terrain

Player questions

- What detail in The Ritual Begins tells you the official story is incomplete?
- Who notices the human cost first, and how do they show it?
- What small object, smell, or sound makes this scene feel real?

Raw source

- Id: S05-03
- Act: Act Five
- Title: The Ritual Begins
- Beats: Lore reveal Combat Roll/check
- Image: assets/scenes/S05-03-the-ritual-begins.png
- Short: The Keystone responds, the countdown starts, and the first enemies emerge.
- Long: This is the objective fight: protect the Custodian, defeat enemies, tick down the ritual clock.
- Read: The Keystone finally answers. The Custodian lifts from the ground, glowing like a lantern about to crack.
- Gm: Place PCs, Custodian, skeletons, and wraiths. Explain countdown simply and visibly.
- Entities: Whitefire Custodian Keystone Asset Ritual Countdown Legacy Security Skeleton The Stones of the Vale The Miremist Moonglow Open Vale? Ritual Site Goldspire Territories Sablewood? Logistics Preserve Eeligator Scale Shield Soul-Audit Wraith Eeligator Damage / Armor Fear
- Choices: Protect Custodian Intercept skeletons Focus fire Use terrain
- Prompt: Whitefire Custodian begins ward renewal ritual over glowing Keystone Asset, magical rings flare, party forms defensive circle, first cracks appear; no strixwolf, no Bramble Union.
- Source Entities: Whitefire Custodian Keystone Asset Ritual Countdown Legacy Security Skeleton

- Beat Codes: lore-reveal combat roll-check
- Slug: S05-03-the-ritual-begins
- Act Title: The Ward Renewal
- Arc Role: Ordeal, ritual defense, and restoration
- Caption: The ritual begins, and the system's unpaid risks answer.
- Image Alt: The Ritual Begins scene art for The Ward Renewal.
- Image Prompt Used: Whitefire Custodian begins ward renewal ritual over glowing Keystone Asset, magical rings flare, party forms defensive circle, first cracks appear; no strixwolf, no Bramble Union. Do not include the Strixwolf Mother, strixwolf pups, wolves, owlbeats, or animal companions unless explicitly requested. No Strixwolf. No Bramble Union. Only Legacy Security Skeletons and Soul-Audit Wraiths as threats. 4:3 cinematic fantasy concept art, no visible text, no captions, no logos, no UI, no watermark.
- Long Storyboard: This is the objective fight: protect the Custodian, defeat enemies, tick down the ritual clock. Run this scene as ordeal, ritual defense, and restoration: The ritual begins, and the system's unpaid risks answer. Keep the camera close to practical choices, visible consequences, and the difference between ordinary people and the infrastructure pressing on them.
- Read Aloud: The Keystone finally answers. The Custodian lifts from the ground, glowing like a lantern about to crack.
- Gm Notes: Place PCs, Custodian, skeletons, and wraiths. Explain countdown simply and visibly. Keep player-facing information actionable. Reveal systemic truth through objects, reactions, and consequences before naming it. The final ritual is now anchored in PDF Sablewood: old blue stones, mist, and luminous river logic under the corporate ritual label. Manufactured-threat lens: seed the contradiction, do not explain it. The surface goal stays simple and heroic. [REFLAVOR/GUARANTEED] Soul-Audit Wraiths bear audit glyphs and say, "Unlicensed soul-resonance detected. Submit for audit."
- Sensory Details: white flame pouring sideways stone dust lifting upward old alarms without bells
- Body Language: The Custodian cannot defend herself while channeling Enemies move toward obligation, not hatred
- Sample Dialogue: Whitefire Custodian Hold them away from the line. If the line breaks, it remembers fear first.
- Checks: Group defense Hold positions as the countdown starts. Standard Start the ritual clock with advantages or complications. 15 Clearly resolve: Hold positions as the countdown starts. Add a concrete boon, extra clue, or improved position. Success, plus the player names one helpful detail or asks one follow-up question. Success, but the GM exposes a cost, ticks a countdown, or reveals a new pressure tied to The Ritual Begins. The full goal slips, but the party still learns a useful truth or avoids the worst consequence. The GM makes a hard move that follows from the fiction and leaves the next choice visible. Spend Fear to tick the ritual countdown, expose the Custodian, activate ward backlash, or trigger Market Correction. On mixed or sliding results, reveal information in layers: visible fact, actionable clue, then systemic truth.
- Choices Consequences: Prioritize ritual line Protects ward stability. Some enemies reach the party. Prioritize enemy elimination Reduces attacks. The Custodian may take narrative pressure.

- Clues: Ritual countdown The ward is activating. Stability depends on protection, not damage output alone. The party can see progress and danger. Guaranteed seed Soul-Audit Wraiths bear audit glyphs and say, "Unlicensed soul-resonance detected. Submit for audit." Soul-Audit Wraiths bear audit glyphs and say, "Unlicensed soul-resonance detected. Submit for audit."
- Loot: Ritual Countdown table Open Vale residue after completion Eeligator Scale Shield: A round shield of overlapping slick green-grey scales catches the light like river-water. It smells of deep water, mud, and old teeth.
- Payoff Flags: Ward Stability Track
- Filters: act-five choice combat gm-only lore-reveal rollcheck the-ward-renewal ward-stability-track npc manufactured-threat guaranteed-earned clue
- Index: 20
- Player Questions: What detail in The Ritual Begins tells you the official story is incomplete? Who notices the human cost first, and how do they show it? What small object, smell, or sound makes this scene feel real?
- Relationship Prompts: Which PC quietly checks on someone else here? Who disagrees about the right thing to do without breaking trust?
- Ownership Prompt: Name one detail in The Ritual Begins that belongs to your character's point of view.
- Reveal Hooks: Loreborne or Knowledge-focused PCs can read the institutional layer. Wildborne/community-focused PCs can read local custom and ecological stress. Martial/security-focused PCs can read threat posture and custody logic. Magic-focused PCs can feel ward tone, soul-signal, or spell instability. Loreborne: spots older legal, heraldic, or ward-craft language under the branding. Underborne: notices service doors, hidden routes, and who built the thing nobody credits. Highborne: reads etiquette, class panic, and reputational risk. Ridgeborne: notices stonework, weight, pressure, and structural weakness. Wildborne: reads the land, animals, and local ecological stress. Elf/Ribbet/Human/Giant/Katari: invite one sensory or social detail from the player's heritage. Sorcerer/Rogue/Warrior/Guardian/Ranger: give each class one table-facing way to shine without changing the plot.
- Fear Spends: Spend Fear to tick the ritual countdown, expose the Custodian, activate ward backlash, or trigger Market Correction. Tick the Ritual Countdown the wrong direction or expose the Custodian. Trigger Market Correction, Pass-Through, Memory Delve, or Group Attack when fiction supports it.
- Story Scope: Perceived antagonist: the forest. True antagonist: the corporate lie about the forest. The players never confront it directly. They are meant to feel it by the end. Every act offers at least one guaranteed and one earned hint that the danger is manufactured and the forest is not the enemy. Soul-Audit Wraiths bear audit glyphs and say, "Unlicensed soul-resonance detected. Submit for audit." REFLAVOR GUARANTEED A defeated wraith leaves a Soulspire compliance tag or coil-credit token instead of natural remains. ADD GUARANTEED Wraiths ignore forest creatures and home only on ritual soul-magic. ADD EARNED Instinct Medium 15 A player can read the markings and name Soulspire without the GM naming it first. ADD EARNED Knowledge Medium 15 Optional flag: Legacy Skeletons carry scraps of old corporate credentials. FLAG SEED Soul-Audit Wraiths bear audit glyphs and say, "Unlicensed soul-resonance detected. Submit for audit." REFLAVOR GUARANTEED Instinct: target logic. Knowledge: read markings. ACT5 Act 5: Open Vale defense 200 2:40 to 3:20 3:20

countdown 8, skeletons, wraiths, Market Correction Lower the countdown start to 6; cap wraith reinforcements.

- Mechanics: The party is in Act Five pressure: The Keystone responds, the countdown starts, and the first enemies emerge. Use Daggerheart Duality Dice as baseline. Use the listed Difficulty and outcome options when a roll matters. Keep trivial actions no-roll; roll only when uncertainty, cost, or danger is interesting. s05-03-shield-the-custodian S05-03 Shield the Custodian Shield the Custodian Agility Strength Agility Strength 13 Agility intercepts; Strength holds the line. The ritual countdown ticks the wrong way. Critical Success: best possible version of the action; gain Hope and clear 1 Stress. Add an extra benefit that follows from the fiction. Success with Hope: the PC gets what they wanted and gains Hope. Keep the position clean or generous. Success with Fear: the PC gets what they wanted, but the GM gains Fear and introduces a cost, complication, or pressure. Failure with Hope: the PC does not get the full result, but gains Hope and receives a useful thread, clue, or safer next option. Failure with Fear: the PC fails and the GM gains Fear. Make a hard move that follows from the fiction. The ritual countdown ticks the wrong way. Use a hard complication, lost time, worse position, GM...
- Roll Cards: s05-03-shield-the-custodian S05-03 Shield the Custodian Shield the Custodian Agility Strength Agility Strength 13 Agility intercepts; Strength holds the line. The ritual countdown ticks the wrong way. Critical Success: best possible version of the action; gain Hope and clear 1 Stress. Add an extra benefit that follows from the fiction. Success with Hope: the PC gets what they wanted and gains Hope. Keep the position clean or generous. Success with Fear: the PC gets what they wanted, but the GM gains Fear and introduces a cost, complication, or pressure. Failure with Hope: the PC does not get the full result, but gains Hope and receives a useful thread, clue, or safer next option. Failure with Fear: the PC fails and the GM gains Fear. Make a hard move that follows from the fiction. The ritual countdown ticks the wrong way. Use a hard complication, lost time, worse position, GM Fear, or mark Stress. Apply an official condition only if the fiction and rules justify it. The attempt falls short, but a partial thread appears. Offer one clue, weak position, or safer follow-up. The PC gets the core result, but it costs time, noise, leverage, or a visible resource. The result lands...
- Conditions Hazards: Vulnerable
- Search Loot Clues: No fixed loot. Offer clue, texture, or hospitality only when the fiction supports it.
- No Roll Guidance: Do not call for a roll when the players have time, a clear method, and no meaningful pressure.
- Tv Mechanics Caption: Public cue: The Ritual Begins asks what the party does, what it costs, and who is protected.
- Trait Variety Note: Primary traits in this scene: Agility, Finesse, Knowledge, Strength. If rolls drift toward Instinct/Presence, ask whether Agility, Strength, Finesse, or Knowledge better describes the action.
- Location Ids: open-valetm-ritual-site goldspire-territories sablewoodtm-logistics-preserve-the-miremist the-stones-of-the-vale
- Item Ids: eeligator-scale-shield
- Clueids: glass-bright-ward-sand
- Clue Ids: glass-bright-ward-sand
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